

In brief

Senthilkumar wins Budapest Open squash

India's Velavan Senthilkumar won his maiden PSA Copper-level crown at the Budapest Open squash in the Hungarian capital, defeating Balazs Farkas in the summit clash, reports PTI from Budapest.

The world No. 54 and eighth-seeded Indian player beat the local favourite Farkas 11-4, 11-2, 11-3 in the final of the USD 43,500 prize money tournament for his 11th PSA Tour crown.

It was also their third meeting on the Tour, with Senthilkumar winning their previous meeting in 2024.

LSC post 9-0 victory

Prajwal, Sugu and Poovai-ah scored a brace each as Leo's Sports Club thrashed Ideal Sports Club, KGF 9-0 in the KSHA State-level Travancore Cup hockey tournament on Saturday, reports DHNS.

Results: Leo's Sports Club: 9 (Prajwal 12th, 29th, Sugu 15th, 26th, Poovai-ah 16th, 47th, Gowtham 18th, Rama 23rd, Nihil 49th) bt Ideal Sports Club, KGF: 0; BCYA: 3 (Nithin S 38th, 41st, Sohan Kadli 46th) bt IISC Gymkhana: 0.

Umadevi wears billiards crown

BENGALURU, DHNS: R Umadevi scored two dominant wins from as many matches to clinch the women's State-ranking billiards tournament here at the KSBA hall on Saturday.



Umadevi, a multi-time champion, first blanked Sameeksha Devan 2-0 (75-8, 75-29) before showing good game awareness to down Keerthana Pandian 2-0 (75-55, 77-61) in hard-fought contest.

Results: R Umadevi bt Sameeksha Devan 2-0 (75-8, 75-29); Keerthana Pandian bt Sameeksha Devan 2-0 (80-16, 76-26); R Umadevi bt Keerthana P 2-0 (75-55, 77-61).

Final placings: R Umadevi 1; Keerthana Pandian 2; Sameeksha Devan 3.

Pranavi lies T8 at Irish Open

KILDARE (IRELAND), PTI: Rising Indian golf sensation Pranavi Urs emerged as the sole Indian to qualify for the weekend rounds at the prestigious KPMG Women's Irish Open.

Delivering a resilient performance at the Palmer South course at The K Club, Pranavi carded a solid two-under-par 70 in her second round to secure a spot tied for eighth place. While her steady play kept Indian hopes alive, a highly competitive global field means she faces a steep uphill battle.

ON TV

CRICKET
2nd Test: England vs Pakistan (Day 4, 3:30 pm). **LIVE on Sony Sports Network, Sony LIV.**

Women's Asia Cup: India vs Thailand (8 pm). **LIVE on Sony Sports Network, Sony LIV.**

Duleep Trophy: South Zone vs North Zone, Central Zone vs East Zone (Day 1, both 9:30 am). **LIVE on JioHotstar, Star Sports Khel.**

HOCKEY
Men's World Cup: Netherlands vs Argentina (bronze medal match, 5:30 pm), Spain vs Germany (final, 8 pm). **LIVE on Star Sports Network, JioHotstar.**

FOOTBALL
EPL: Chelsea vs Brighton, Leeds United vs Brentford, Sunderland vs Fulham (all 6:30 pm), Man United vs Ipswich (9 pm). **LIVE on Star Sports Network, JioHotstar.**

La Liga: Real Madrid vs Malaga (8:30 pm), Deportivo vs Valencia (11 pm), Celta Vigo vs Athletic Bilbao (1 am, Monday). **LIVE on FanCode.**

TENNIS
US Open: 1st round (8:30 pm). **LIVE on Star Sports Network, JioHotstar.**

Fancied India look to feast on Thai starter

Good opportunity for Women In Blue to iron out T20 flaws

DUBAI, PTI

Harmanpreet Kaur's India will look to banish their ordinary run in the shortest format while facing questions over their consistency and form as they take on Thailand in their Women's T20 Asia Cup Group A opener here on Sunday.

India have been the most dominant team in the Women's T20 Asia Cup over the last decade -- winning the title thrice in five editions of the T20 format since 2016-17 -- but their performances bring forth more concerns than assurances at the moment.

India have lost nine of 16 T20Is this year, and their most recent loss -- against Australia in the Women's T20 World Cup -- knocked them out of the competition at the group stage itself.

With questions persisting over captain Harmanpreet's own form and future in the shortest format, India head into a crucial phase of competing in two Asian-level competitions in which they would be

expected to go the distance. Following the eight-team Women's T20 Asia Cup, where India are placed in Group A along with Thailand, Hong Kong and Pakistan, they will head into next month's Asian Games in Japan with expectations high to bring more laurels to the country.

Having endured a largely disappointing campaign in the Women's T20 World Cup, Harmanpreet fired in the all-important clash against Australia, but her inconsistency with the bat remained one of the talking points from the campaign in which India struggled against higher-ranked teams.

With dependable batter Jemimah Rodrigues sidelined for the Asia Cup and Asian Games, India have added Pratiksha Rawal to their star-studded squad, but the choice hardly settles the requirement for a middle-order enforcer.

At the top, India will continue to have the formidable opening pair of Smriti Mandhana and Shafali Verma, but the biggest challenge for batters at No. 3 and beyond would be to sus-



Captain Harmanpreet Kaur will be looking to lead from the front when India take on Thailand in their opening clash of the Women's T20 Asia Cup in Dubai on Sunday. PTI FILE PHOTO

tain momentum and provide further impetus to the scoreboard. Poor fielding was again a major concern the last time India played in the format, as a string of dropped chances near the ropes led to their downfall, and the team management would be desperate to have their bases covered this time around.

India will rely on their seasoned all-rounder Deepti Sharma to lead the spin attack once again, with Shree Charani, the highest wicket-taker of the T20 World Cup, Radha Yadav and Prema Rawat sharing the workload.

India's seam bowling arsenal

looks potent too, with the experienced Renuka Singh Thakur having the likes of Kranti Gaud, Arundhati Reddy and Nandani Sharma to share the responsibilities.

Thailand, meanwhile, will look to draw confidence from their victory over Hong Kong in their opening match, for which they had to work hard. A sedate start led to Thailand finishing at a modest 120 for nine, but they did well with the ball and in the field to restrict Hong Kong to 114 for seven.

Skipper Naruemoi Chaiwai (43) held their batting together, while Onnichha Kamchom-

phu (3/27) and Phannita Maya (2/22) impressed with the ball.

Teams (from): India: Harmanpreet Kaur (capt), Smriti Mandhana (vc), Bharti Fulmali, Richa Ghosh (wk), Gulan Kamalini (wk), Pratika Rawal, Shafali Verma, Deepti Sharma, Kranti Gaud, Prema Rawat, Arundhati Reddy, Renuka Singh Thakur, Nandani Sharma, Shree Charani, Radha Yadav.

Thailand: Naruemoi Chaiwai (capt), Nannaphat Chaihan, Natthakan Chantham, Naomi Hilton, Nannapat Koncharoenkai (wk), Onnichha Kamchomphu, Phannita Maya, Chanida Sutthiruang, Aphisara Suwanchorathi, Sunida Chaturongrattana, Chayanisa Phengpaen, Suleeporn Laomi, Thipatcha Putthawong, Thanrada Seesawan, Koranit Suwanchorathi.

South Zone have their task cut out

North banking on potent bowling to get the job done

VIGNESH BHARADWAJ
BENGALURU, DHNS

In this day and age of dime-a-dozen cricket matches, a five-game red-ball tournament would on most occasions be brushed aside as inconsequential. However, in the Indian domestic scene, things are done a little differently.

Having sailed into the Duleep Trophy semifinals by virtue of playing the final last year, a highly-talented South Zone will look to negate a potential threat from a dangerous North unit at the BCCI's Centre of Excellence Ground 2 here.

For the hosts, it will be a case of hoping that history repeats itself, while North will look to rewrite the pages of the last two semifinal meetings. After reporting to CoE on Friday, South Zone have clocked in two "quality" sessions and are in good shape.

"The preparation has been good. We had two quality team sessions and things look in good shape. We are ready to go," head coach Vikram Verma told DH.

"As we're playing on a black soil surface, Tilak (Varma) and I will have a final look at the



Karnataka's Smaran R will look to start the season strong when South Zone take on North in the Duleep Trophy semifinal at the BCCI's Centre of Excellence on Sunday. DH FILE PHOTO

wicket and will make a decision on the XI."

This though isn't just about the semifinal, but also an audition for India A hopefuls, with two four-day games against Australia A starting September 22.

Karnataka's Smaran R, who was vocal about his expectations after missing out on the India A tour to Sri Lanka, will look to log in some big runs to keep his name among the selectors' discussions.

The southpaw's confidence will be high after a brilliant last season (950 runs) in the Ranji Trophy, and South Zone would be hoping that it rubs off on his team-mates.

Similarly, his State-mate

Karun Nair would eye a strong start to the season after a superb run with the bat last time. Joining the two Karnataka boys in the middle-order is India's T20 vice-captain Tilak Varma. The 26-year-old will get a golden chance to prove his red-ball leadership credentials. Meanwhile, Narayan Jagadeesan, the lone representative from Tamil Nadu, is expected to be the first-choice wicketkeeper.

On the bowling front, Karnataka leg-spinner Shreyas Gopal could also be closely monitored. After Saransh Jain and Aaquib Nabi received India call-ups, the 32-year-old will be looking to build on the reputation.

The hosts will bank on pac-

OTHER SEMI
Central Zone vs East Zone

ers Vidwath Kaverappa and MD Nidheesh to put their best foot forward with the new ball.

Meanwhile, North Zone will hope to iron out their batting wrinkles from a nervy quarters win over West. The dressing room was also hit with criticism after Ranji Trophy's third-highest run-getter Sanat Sangwan was made to sit out.

North have received a boost after India quick Gurnoor Brar was added to the squad and is likely to replace Sunil Kumar in the XI, giving a better look to the fast bowling department consisting of Arshdeep Singh and Anshul Kamboj. North will also look towards Abid Mushtaq, who picked up 9/99 in the quarters, to shepherd them into the final.

Experience favours South, but the fighting spirit and time in the middle give North an advantage. So this one promises to be a cracker.

Teams: South Zone: Tilak Varma (c), Ricky Bhui (vc), Abhinav Tejirana, SK Rasheed, K Himateja, Smaran R, N Jagadeesan, Karun Nair, T Thyagarajan, Shreyas Gopal, K Sai Teja, T Vijay, Vidwath Kaverappa, Aman Khan, MD Nidheesh.

North Zone: Kanhaiya Wadhwani (c), Ayush Badoni (vc), Sanat Sangwan, Qamran Iqbal, Yash Dhull, Ayush Doseja, Abdul Samad, Nishant Sindhu, Arjun Sharma, Abid Mushtaq, Arshdeep Singh, Sunil Kumar, Anshul Kamboj, Nikhil Kashyap, Gurnoor Brar.

Muzumdar wants aggressive cricket

DUBAI, PTI

Indian women's cricket team head coach Amol Muzumdar is not too fazed by the side's recent form and wants his young team to play "aggressive" cricket at the Women's T20 Asia Cup and set the tone for next six months, which includes the Asian Games campaign.

India face a key reality check in the shortest format following recent inconsistencies on overseas tours and at global tournaments.

India, who have lost nine of their 16 T20Is this year, will open their T20 Asia Cup campaign against Thailand on Sunday.

"We don't pay too much attention to the form. You are talking about 16 T20Is in the last six months. But at the same time, we know what scope of improvement this team has got," Muzumdar told reporters on Saturday.

"There is a huge scope of improvement. There is a young side. I think, if you look at it, we are trying to play some good cricket, good aggressive cricket."

"And from here on, we will try and set the tone for the next six months."

Muzumdar said spinners could play a key role in the humid Dubai conditions.



"I think they are crucial. Spinners definitely are crucial. We have got a variety of spinners in this side. Looking forward to it. They should be up and running."

"In a couple of sessions, we have seen that the pitches have got a little bit of help for the spinners as well. So, I guess some good signs for us. Of course, we focus on the game."

Asked about the prospect of an India-Pakistan clash, Muzumdar preferred to keep the focus on cricket.

"Of course, we don't want to reveal it. Look, we try to play the best cricket on the ground. And off the field stuff, we don't focus on."

"We try to play the best cricket that we know on that particular day. And we will speak about this when we play that game. But at the moment, we are focusing on tomorrow's game."

England take command with big lead

LONDON, AFP: Mohammad Abbas was in the wickets again on Saturday but England built a huge lead of over 300 runs in the second Test against Pakistan at Lord's.

After the morning session was washed out, veteran seamer Abbas had figures of 3-48 when a fresh downpour forced an early tea on the third day, as England looked to go 2-0 up in a three-match series.

That gave Abbas seven wickets for the match following his 4-70 in England's first-innings 290.

But England, with Dan Lawrence 37 not out, reached 162-6 in their second innings -- a commanding advantage of 342 runs.

Pakistan were dismissed for 171 and 135 in an innings and 103-run thumping by England at Headingley last week before collapsing to a woeful 110 all out first time around at Lord's.

They have also never scored more than 234 in the fourth innings of any Test against England in England.

The hosts resumed Saturday on 81-3 in gloomy conditions, barely countered by the floodlights, and on a still green-tinged pitch that also promised to aid Pakistan's pacemen.

Under pressure opener Emilio Gay was 30 not out after a dogged 69-ball display on Friday, when he walked out to bat, averaging just 22.50 from his first eight Test innings.

Brief scores: England: 290 & 162/7 in 45 overs (Emilio Gay, Harry Brook 34, Dan Lawrence 37 n.o.; Mohammad Abbas 3-48, Khuram Shahzad 2-56, Mohammad Ali 2-51) vs Pakistan: 110.



Pakistan's Mohammad Abbas took three scalps against England on the third day of the second Test. AFP

Samit, Dhanush, Hemanth shine for President's XI

BENGALURU, DHNS

Samit Dravid and Dhanush Gowda registered hundreds while Hemanth Patil picked up a five-wicket haul as President's XI bagged the first innings honours in their drawn game against Mysore Zone at the KSCA SA Srinivasan Memorial cricket tournament for Under-23 Men here.

President's XI, batting first and riding on contributions from Samit (142) and Dhanush (115) posted 365/9 declared in 87.4 overs. Hemanth Patil then a bagged five-for to bowl out Mysore Zone cheaply for

144 in 47.2 overs.

In the second essay, President's XI notched up 156/1 in 27 overs as Prakharchaturvedi (99) missed out on a hundred.

Brief scores: At SLS Kreedangana: President's XI: 365/9 decl in 87.4 overs (Anirudh Srinivas 39, Samit Dravid 142, Dhanush Gowda 115; Rajashekhar Swamy 2-44, Samarsh Hegde 2-65, Bhuvnesh P Nayak 2-69) & 156/1 in 27 overs (Prakharchaturvedi 99, Arnab Mishra 52 n.o.) drew with Mysore Zone: 144 all out in 47.2 overs (M Kanishk 42, Praneth Shetty 33; Tejas KA 2-16, Dhruv Vasu 3-47,



Samit Dravid

Hemanth Patil 5-22).
President's XI: 3 points; Mysore Zone: 1 point.
At CMR University: Secretary's XI: 263/9 in 70.1 overs (Bhuvan M Raju 43, Yuvraj A 75, Gourav P 39, Karthikeya KP 34, Mohsin Khan 36; Amritha Praveen 5-24, Adithya A Kotian 2-43, Adithya A Kotian 2-43, Dhanush drew with Mangalore Zone: 202 all out in 66.4 overs (Gagan Rao 5 39, Rushi B Shetty 48, Nischith Pai 52 n.o.; Pranav Aswath 4-41, Sidharth Akhil 2-51, Mohsin Khan 3-14).
Secretary's XI: 3; Mangalore Zone: 1.
At Kreedha Kshetra (B): Dharwad Zone: 175 all out in 50.1 overs (Rohan M Yareshmi 46; Virat R Ganya 2-23,

Lohith S 5-74, Ajith MC 2-27) & 117/7 in 35.3 overs (Siddesh A Asalkar 65; Virat R Ganya 4-37, Ajith MC 2-20) drew with Shivamogga Zone: 181 all out in 71.3 overs (Tanmay M 53; Karan K Bokade 3-39, Siddappa J Pujeri 4-32, Advait A Sathaye 2-26).
Shivamogga Zone: 3; Dharwad Zone: 1.
At Green Sports Village: 381/6 in 90 overs (Sireesh Balgaar 90, Bhushan DS 84, Karan U 44, Krishav Somasundar 49, Karan Surya Vamsi 84 n.o.; Rahul Bellad 3-69, Vivek Naik 2-73) drew with Raichur Zone: 193/5 in 60.3 overs (Vijaya Raj B 83, Harsha Wardhan Khuba 59 n.o., Karan Surya Vamsi 2-14, Dheeraaj Gowda 2-57). (Match drawn, first innings unfinished due to inclement weather).
Bangalore City XI: 1; Raichur Zone: 1.